When the State Matches

Justifying Demographic Goals in Dating-App Design

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Slides

Aim and Argument

Aim

Assess Beckstein & de Vries's (2025) defense of demographic weighting without explicit user consent.

Claim

The current defense does not adequately assess whether the weighting's additional benefits justify its effects on encounter opportunities.

My Main Argument

(P1) If the current defense adequately justifies demographic weighting, it provides an adequate assessment of the weighting's additional benefits and the burdens of reduced encounter opportunities.

(P2) The current defense, considered as a whole, does not provide that assessment.

(C) Therefore, the current defense does not adequately justify demographic weighting.

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Two Proposals: Public Apps and Demographic Design

Bouke de Vries (2024)

State-Run Dating Apps: Are They Morally Desirable?

Public provision could correct commercial incentives and help users find lasting relationships.

Martin Beckstein and Bouke de Vries (2025)

Dating Apps as Tools for Social Engineering

Matching design could pursue public goals, including fertility.

Disputed step: Can this justify demographic weighting without explicit user consent?

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de Vries (2024): A Public Dating App

Commercial incentives

Continued searching and spending can generate revenue.

Public provision

Successful relationships can count as success even when users leave the app.

Proposals include priority for users seeking long-term relationships, transparency, independent oversight, and commercial alternatives.

de Vries 2024, pp. 2–3, 9, 12.

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Beckstein and de Vries (2025): Two Designs

	Preference-responsive matching	Demographic weighting
Criterion	Compatible reproductive plans	Expected demographic contribution
Mechanism	User-selected filters	Additional changes to visibility
Purpose	Help users pursue their aims	Advance a population goal

Preference-responsive matching follows users' family plans. Demographic weighting adds a state-selected criterion for how profiles are shown.

Beckstein & de Vries 2025, pp. 5–6, 9.

Beckstein and de Vries: Demographic Weighting

Beckstein and de Vries's proposal (2025)

Favor matches expected to support childbirth or stable child-rearing, even without explicit user consent.

Beckstein & de Vries 2025, p. 9.

Their stated permissibility claim

In some circumstances, the benefits can justify the costs.

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Their Defense: An Argument Reconstruction

(D1) If demographic weighting can secure sufficiently important public benefits while imposing only acceptable burdens, it can be permissible without explicit consent.

(D2) Demographic weighting can secure sufficiently important public benefits while imposing only acceptable burdens.

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Reasons offered for D2

Commercial apps already constrain choices; demographic gains can protect freedom; no relationship is prohibited.

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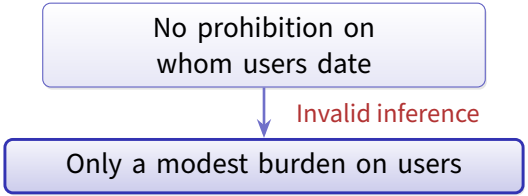
Reconstruction of Beckstein & de Vries 2025, p. 9.

Three Gaps in the Defense

Reason offered	Gap in the justification
Commercial constraints	Bundles public provision with demographic weighting
Demographic benefits	Identifies a goal without justifying the matching criterion
No prohibition	Leaves the burden on encounter opportunities unmeasured

Nonprohibition Leaves Encounter Burdens Unmeasured

Beckstein and de Vries (2025, p. 9):



An app can leave every relationship legally available while making some potential partners much harder to encounter. The absence of a ban therefore does not determine how demanding the intervention is.

Beckstein & de Vries 2025, p. 9.

My Counterexample: Reduced Visibility

Suppose

A widely used public app repeatedly reduces some profiles' visibility because of their expected demographic contribution.

(P1) If nonprohibition alone established a modest burden, no intervention could preserve final choice while imposing a substantial burden on encounter opportunities.

(P2) Repeated visibility reductions on a widely relied-on app can preserve final choice while imposing such a burden.

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The Authors' Standard of Freedom

(P1) If effective opportunities matter when assessing an intervention's freedom gains, they also matter when assessing its freedom costs.

(P2) The defense assesses freedom gains by the effective opportunities protected against work and caregiving burdens.

(C) Their assessment of demographic weighting's freedom costs must also consider effective opportunities.

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Star and Ruhleder: Infrastructural Dependence

Encounter opportunities

The significance of a ranking depends on how people rely on the service to meet others.

Star & Ruhleder 1996, pp. 112–113.

- Intensity of the adjustment
- Duration of the adjustment
- Reliance on the service
- Availability of alternatives

My Argument: Public Purposes and Means

(P1) When the state changes citizens' important opportunities for a collective purpose, it must justify that means and its allocation of burdens to the citizens affected.

(P2) Demographic weighting changes citizens' important encounter opportunities for a collective population goal.

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Lazar: Ends, Procedures, and Authority

Ends
What should the system pursue?

Procedures
How should decisions be made?

Authority
Who may exercise this power?

A public purpose requires justified procedures and authority. The public mandate must cover the criterion through which the system changes citizens' opportunities.

Lazar 2024, preprint, §3.4, pp. 22–24; §4, p. 27.

Three Questions for Demographic Weighting

1. Why pursue population goals through the ordering of intimate encounters?
2. What additional benefits justify the burdens, given feasible alternatives?
3. Who can authorize, challenge, and revise the objective and the weighting?

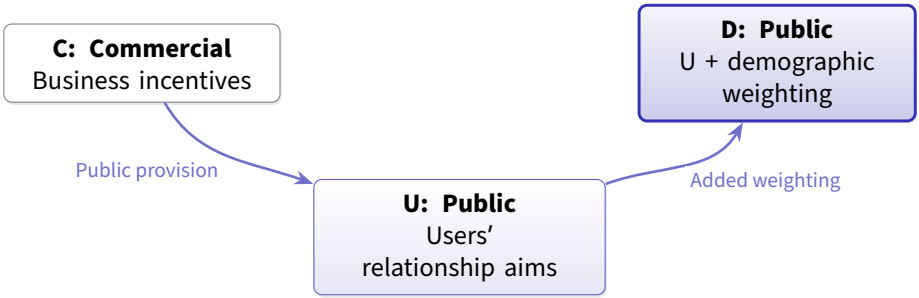
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My Comparison: Public Provision and Weighting



Moving from C to D changes both public provision and demographic direction. If public provision creates gains and weighting removes some of them, D can still outperform C. Comparing D with feasible U isolates the additional weighting's effects.

The Wrong Baseline for Demographic Weighting

(P1) A comparison that changes both public provision and demographic weighting does not isolate the effects of the weighting.

(P2) The comparison between C and D changes both public provision and demographic weighting.

(C) The C–D comparison does not isolate the effects of demographic weighting.

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The Defense Does Not Justify the Added Weighting

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Possible Reply: Public Benefit and Freedom

(P1) Every possible design whose public benefits justify its burdens and that is appropriately authorized is permissible.

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(P1) If oversight and explanation can provide the required assessment of benefits and burdens, they can meet the proposed assessment requirement.

(P2) Properly designed oversight and explanation can provide the required assessment of benefits and burdens.

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Democratic scrutiny and monitoring: de Vries (2024); Beckstein & de Vries (2025). Explanation rights: de Vries & González Barman (2026).

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My Reply: Assessing Benefits and Burdens

(P1) An adequate judgment that benefits justify encounter burdens requires an assessment of the magnitude and distribution of those burdens.

(P2) Nonprohibition and general demographic benefits do not provide that assessment of encounter burdens.

(C) Those considerations alone do not establish an adequate judgment that the benefits justify the encounter burdens.

Urgency, effectiveness, reliance, and feasible alternatives bear on that assessment.

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Explanation

Which criterion reduced visibility?

What can the user change?

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Why is that criterion justified?

What should the state change?

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